

Dictamnus albus (Rutaceae)

Dittany, Burning Bush

Description Strongly aromatic, bushy, and hairy perennial growing to 32 in (80 cm). Has compound leaves and spikes of 5-petaled white or pink flowers streaked with purple.

Habitat & Cultivation This herb grows in southern and central Europe and northern Asia, preferring warm, wooded areas. The flowering tops are gathered in late summer; the root generally in autumn.

Parts Used Root, flowering tops.



Dittany flowers were formerly used to make a preparation that was sniffed up the nose as a treatment for head colds.

Constituents Dittany's potent volatile oil contains estragol and anethole, and a toxic alkaloid, dictamnin.

History & Folklore Dittany exudes such large amounts of volatile oil that in hot, dry conditions, a match held close will cause the whole plant to burst into flames. The plant has been used to flavor liqueurs and has been brewed as a tea in parts of Siberia. In European folk medicine, dittany was considered an antidote to poison, pestilence, and the bites of all types of venomous animals.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Very rarely used by herbalists today, dittany has an action similar to that of rue (*Ruta graveolens*, p. 265), in that it strongly stimulates the muscles of the uterus, inducing menstruation and sometimes causing abortion. By contrast, its effect on the gastrointestinal tract is antispasmodic. Dittany relaxes the gut and acts as a mild tonic for the stomach. The plant has also been used as a treatment for nervous conditions.

⚠️ Cautions This herb is toxic. Take only under professional supervision. Do not take during pregnancy.

Digitalis lutea (Scrophulariaceae)

Yellow Foxglove

Description Erect perennial growing to 3 ft (1 m). Has narrow, lance-shaped leaves, and long spikes of yellow, bell-shaped flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to western and central Europe, this herb grows in woodland areas, on roadsides, and in mountainous regions. It is cultivated for medicinal use in Russia. The leaves are harvested in the second summer of growth.

Parts Used Leaves.

Constituents Yellow foxglove contains cardiac glycosides (including the cardenolides alpha-acetyldigitoxin, acetyldigitoxin, and lanatoside). All act to strengthen the beating of a weakened heart.

History & Folklore Unlike the closely related common foxglove (*D. purpurea*, following entry), yellow foxglove does not appear to have played a significant role in European herbal medicine.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Yellow foxglove is little employed in herbal medicine, but in fact it is a less toxic alternative to purple foxglove and woolly foxglove (*D. lanata*). It has similar medicinal actions but its alkaloids are more readily metabolized and flushed out by the body. Like other foxgloves, this plant supports a weakened or failing heart, increasing the strength of contraction, slowing and steadying the heart rate, and lowering blood pressure by strongly stimulating the production of urine, which reduces overall blood volume.

Related Species Common foxglove (following entry).

⚠️ Cautions Excessive doses of yellow foxglove can prove fatal. Use only under professional supervision. This plant is subject to legal restrictions in some countries.

Digitalis purpurea (Scrophulariaceae)

Common Foxglove, Purple Foxglove

Description Perennial growing to 5 ft (1.5 m). Has a single erect stem, broad lance-shaped leaves, and bell-shaped, purple-pink or white flowers in long spikes.

Habitat & Cultivation This herb is native to western Europe. Though it is also cultivated, the wild plant is considered superior. The leaves are picked in summer.

Parts Used Leaves.

Constituents Foxglove contains cardiac glycosides (including digoxin, digitoxin, and lanatosides), anthraquinones, flavonoids, and saponins. Digitoxin

rapidly strengthens the heartbeat, but is excreted very slowly. Digoxin is therefore preferred as a long-term medication.

History & Folklore In medical history, foxglove is best known as the discovery of William Withering, an 18th-century English country doctor. Curious about the formula of a local herbalist, he explored the plant's potential medical uses. His work led to the production of a life-saving medicine.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Foxglove has a profound tonic effect on a diseased heart. Heart disease worsens when the heart's ability to maintain normal circulation decreases. Foxglove's cardiac glycosides enable the heart to beat more strongly, slowly, and regularly, without requiring more oxygen. At the same time, it stimulates urine production, which lowers the volume of blood, and thus lessens the load on the heart.

Related Species Woolly foxglove (*D. lanata*) is today the main source of cardiac glycosides.

⚠️ Cautions

Potentially fatal in overdose. Use only under professional supervision. This plant is subject to legal restrictions.



Common foxglove enables the heart to beat more evenly and is an invaluable remedy for heart disease.